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JAPAN'S EIGHTFOLD FENCE

Foreign Policy, National Identity, and the Struggle for Internationalism

> Eight clouds arise. The eightfold fence of Idzumo makes an eightfold fence for the spouses to retire [within]. Oh! that eightfold fence.
>
> —*Kojiki* (Records of ancient matters, 712 CE)

When the first Europeans landed on Japan's shores in the sixteenth century, the island nation appeared a land set apart from the rest of the world. Shrouded in clouds, its peaks glowing verdantly, Japan seemed to harbor endless mysteries just beyond the shoreline. Upon landing, Portuguese missionaries and Dutch traders found a civilization almost entirely different from any they had encountered before. By the standards of the day it was advanced, though without the technological prowess of Europe. Divided into warring feudal domains, sixteenth-century Japan was locked in the midst of a century-long civil war to determine which samurai clan would rule the rest. Armies of tens of thousands of armored warriors met in narrow plains, under the shadow

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